THE FAMILY TREE

MAHARAJA SAWAI MADHO SINGH
(1880–1922)

SAWAI MAN SINGH
(1922–1970)
adopted son, who ascended to the Jaipur throne

MAN SINGH HAD THREE WIVES

MARUDHAR KANWAR
Princess of Jodhpur (married in 1924)

- **BHAWANI SINGH** (died in 2011) succeeded Man Singh as Maharaja. Married Princess Padmini Devi of Sirmaur
  - **DIYA KUMARI** has three children
    - **PADMANABH** (Elder son) was adopted as Bhawani Singh's son and heir to Jaipur gaddi
    - **GAURAVI KUMARI** (Daughter)
    - **LAKSHYARAJ** has been adopted as titular kin of Sirmaur from where Padmini Devi hails
- **PREM KUMARI**

KISHORE KANWAR
Princess of Jodhpur (married in 1932)

- **JAI SINGH**
  - Got Jhilai *thikana* and married Vidya Devi of Jubbal and has one son, **Ajay Singh**
- **PRITHVI SINGH** (son, died in 2020)
  - Got Bhagwatgarh *thikana*, married Devika of Tripura, daughter of Gayatri Devi's elder sister and has one son, **Vijit Singh**

GAYATRI DEVI
Princess of Cooch Behar (married in 1940, died in 2009)

- **JAGAT SINGH** (died 1997) Married Priyanandana Rangsit of Thailand, got Isarda Thikana
  - **DEVRAJ SINGH**
  - **LALITYA KUMARI**





↘ EMERGENCE OF A HALF-THAI PRINCE

Devraj Singh has emerged as a prominent face in Jaipur royal disputes. Gayatri Devi's grandson not only represents her legacy, but is also the Maharaj of Isarda, the most significant *thikana*, from where important heirs to the throne, including his grandfather Man Singh, were adopted in the past. He says he intends to spend the earnings from his inheritance on the locals. He has also called on the government to name a garden after Gayatri Devi for what she has done for women's empowerment. True to his royal upbringing, he has also joined the Thai Nationalist Party to defend the monarchy back home.

prime land and other assets. And everything chugged along smoothly until 1989 when, it is widely believed, Prithvi Singh, who was elected as MP from Dausa on the Swatantra Party's ticket in 1972, plotted with brothers Jai Singh and Jagat Singh, as well as Gayatri Devi, to challenge his eldest brother's male primogeniture claim over all the royal properties. It is said that they wanted another male heir to be picked and declared maharaja since Bhawani Singh had only one child, a daughter. They said all the properties other than those gifted be divided equally among all four brothers. The fallout: a good section of the properties Bhawani Singh had inherited was taken over by a court-appointed receiver, excluding a small part of the City Palace and Jaigarh Fort, since both are under his family trust.

The betrayal, his family still believes, caused Bhawani Singh to suffer a paralytic attack, which he never recovered fully from. The court cases pertaining to these are still pending.

There was allegedly another strategic coup, one in which Bhawani's one-fourth share in the Ram Bagh Palace was gradually reduced to less than 4 per cent as was Jagat Singh's and the remaining two shareholders' stake rose to more than 90 per cent. The same strategy was allegedly used for Jai Mahal in 1997 after Jagat Singh died. In 2006, his ex-wife and Thai princess Priyanandana accused Gayatri Devi of producing a fake will of Jagat Singh in which he had denied his children, Devraj and Lalitya, any rights to his property and bequeathed everything to his mother. Gayatri Devi lived in the Lilypool, a small palace adjoining Ram Bagh, but its doors were shut to her grandchildren. At this juncture, Bhawani Singh let Priyanandana and her children stay at City Palace. "I would stay at Chandra Mahal (located within the City Palace), where he would stay too and I am ever grateful to him," Devraj told INDIA TODAY. In 2008, Gayatri Devi agreed to a succession certificate where Jagat Singh's properties were divided equally between her and her two grandchildren, and in 2009, she willed all her properties to them. This left Prithvi and Jai Singh upset as both had, for most of Gayatri Devi's life, taken care of her. After her death, they took control of the Lilypool, but Bhawani Singh ensured Devraj got to live there. Insiders say Bhawani expected the grandchildren to withdraw her challenge to his properties, but that did not happen and relations soured. INDIA TODAY reached out to Jai Singh and Vijit Singh, but both declined to comment.

Devraj's desire to bring all sides together and live in peace might see success, but it is not likely to happen anytime soon. The stakes are high and while it is impossible to put a price on royal heritage, the value could run into thousands of crores. A similar effort to reach a settlement was made about 15 years ago, but nothing came of it. Not much has changed since then. ■